

GARBO, GRETA



SOPHISTICATED, SUPERIOR, scornful, and beautiful, Greta Garbo was everyone's idea of the perfect film star. The daughter of a poor labourer in Stockholm, Sweden, she conquered Hollywood in the 1920s and 1930s. Her audiences adored her, but at the height of her career she retired, becoming a recluse and never showing her face in public again. Yet this most celebrated actor received no Oscars, only a belated special award for her unforgettable films.

Mauritz Stiller

While at training school, Garbo was spotted by the Swedish film director Mauritz Stiller. Stiller was best known for such films as the comedy *Love and Journalism*, and the sexually charged movie *Erotikon*. Stiller took a special interest in Garbo's career, gave her the surname Garbo, and made her into a star.



Garbo and Mauritz Stiller



Training

Early in her career, Garbo appeared as the female lead in a slapstick comedy, *Peter the Tramp*. She then applied for and won a scholarship to Sweden's Royal Dramatic Theatre training school, where she was soon playing small parts on stage.

Early life

Greta Gustafson was born in the Swedish capital of Stockholm in 1905. Her family was poor, and she worked from an early age in a barber's shop and a department store. Her first film part was in *How Not to Dress*, a publicity film for the store.



First success

Garbo's first major film role was as the star of *The Atonement of Gösta Berling*. The film was a romantic tale of a priest set in the Swedish countryside. The premiere in Stockholm in 1924 attracted a huge audience and launched Garbo on her film career.



Still from *Gösta Berling*



Studio system

Film-making in Hollywood was dominated by a few large companies, such as MGM, Paramount, and Warner Bros. These and other studios kept actors and directors on tight contracts, so that they could not work for a rival company. As a result, Garbo was forced to star in films she did not like.



"Garbo talks!"

In 1930, the first sound film starring Garbo appeared. The publicity slogan was "Garbo talks!". The film, *Anna Christie*, had a heroine with a Swedish accent. The producers thought this would be an ideal role for Garbo. They believed that audiences might not otherwise accept her heavily accented voice.

Hollywood

In 1925, after the success of *Gösta Berling*, Garbo moved to Hollywood, the centre of the US film industry. She signed a contract with Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer (MGM) and began filming *The Torrent*. Her first major success was *Flesh and the Devil*, made in 1926 and directed by Clarence Brown. By 1927, she was earning \$5,000 a week from MGM. In all, Garbo made 24 films in Hollywood, and became one of the most famous, and best-paid, film stars in the world.



Anna Karenina

Garbo's reputation as a tragic heroine was established by *Anna Karenina* (1935), based on the novel by the great Russian writer Leo Tolstoy. The film won numerous awards and confirmed Garbo's reputation as the leading actress of her day.

Garbo laughs

Garbo's reputation was as a serious, intense actress. In 1939, she astounded audiences with her relaxed performance in the romantic comedy *Ninotchka*. Publicity for the film made much of her laughter in this role.



A life apart

In 1941, Garbo announced her retirement from making films, having no wish to disappoint her admirers by growing old on screen. Despite her success in Europe, her popularity was declining in the USA. She became an American citizen in 1951 and led the life of a recluse, although she remained friends with many famous people.

"I want to be alone" was Garbo's famous wish after her retirement in 1941.



GRETA GARBO

- 1905 Born in Stockholm, Sweden.
- 1924 Stars in *The Atonement of Gösta Berling*, her first major film.
- 1925 Moves to the USA and signs contract with MGM.
- 1930 Has her first talking role, in *Anna Christie*.
- 1935 *Anna Karenina*.
- 1938 Nominated for an Oscar for *Camille*.
- 1939 *Ninotchka*.
- 1941 Retires from film-making.
- 1954 Honoured at Academy Awards.
- 1990 Dies in New York.

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